

Teaching Statement

Qilin Zhang

I teach economics by starting with the decision or problem that gives the model meaning. Students should understand what an economic idea is trying to explain before they are asked to manipulate equations, interpret a regression, or solve a model. In an introductory course, this means showing students how the methods in the textbook help them think about choices they make in their own lives, rather than asking them to memorize definitions and formulas. I use practice, feedback, and collaboration to help students move from economic intuition to formal analysis and then back to interpretation.

Teaching experience

At the University of Florida, I have served as Instructor of Record for ECP 3703 Managerial Economics since Spring 2026. This is an undergraduate course of about thirty students, and I have direct responsibility for planning the course, presenting the material, designing assessments, and helping students apply basic economic reasoning to business and everyday decisions. My teaching experience also includes serving as a teaching assistant in undergraduate, MBA, master's, and Ph.D. courses, including Managerial Economics, Economic Data Analysis, Intermediate Macroeconomics, International Macroeconomics, Applied Game Theory, Macroeconomic Analysis, Macroeconomic Theory, and Computational Economics. In most of these assignments, I worked within the course structure and assessment plan set by the faculty instructor. The main exception was ECO 7206 Macroeconomic Theory, where I prepared and led a weekly discussion section for a more junior Ph.D. cohort. I reviewed the lecture material, prepared additional explanations, and worked through models and problem sets with students.

Student evaluations from my first semester as Instructor of Record provide encouraging evidence on my teaching. With a response rate of 83.9 percent, students rated my enthusiasm for the course at 4.54 out of 5 and my standards for communication and availability at 4.65. Students also described the chapter worksheets, in-class problems, and practice exams as useful preparation for the course exams. I also opted into the university's voluntary midterm evaluation so that I could respond to students during the semester, and I used their comments to build in more time for working through problems together, step by step. In the following fall semester, I observed more consistent student participation as I continued to use structured practice, group homework, and opportunities for students to explain solutions at the board.

Economic intuition first

I begin a new topic with a concrete decision, a graph, or a short numerical example. In Managerial Economics, for example, students can first reason through how a firm would respond to a change in price, cost, or demand before I introduce the formal optimization problem. Once students can describe the decision in words, the algebra becomes a way to organize that reasoning rather than a set of procedures to memorize.

In a theory course the emphasis shifts. In the ECO 7206 discussion section, I wrote out the steps of each derivation, explained why each step followed, and paused when a common mistake was likely. I drew on the mistakes I had made when learning the material myself to anticipate where students might lose track of an assumption or the interpretation of a result. The aim was not to replace the instructor's lectures, but to give students a patient setting in which to practice solving the models themselves.

I also use group homework to make economic reasoning a shared activity. Students work through problems together, compare their approaches, and explain why an answer makes economic sense. Students should learn how to communicate an argument, respond to a different approach, and take responsibility for a common solution.

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Practice and feedback

Students learn economics by doing economics. I build short practice opportunities into class meetings and assignments rather than relying only on high-stakes exams. A typical activity might ask students to interpret a change in a graph, solve a small problem, explain a result in one paragraph, or revise an answer after seeing a common mistake. I use these exercises to see where the class is struggling and to adjust the pace or explanation before a misunderstanding becomes cumulative.

Feedback should tell students what to do next. On quantitative work, I distinguish an error in economic reasoning from an error in calculation. I also ask students to interpret their answer in words, which helps them see that a technically correct calculation can still be economically incomplete. When possible, I provide worked examples that show not only the final answer but also the decisions that lead to it, including how to check whether the answer is sensible.

Making economic reasoning accessible

I do not treat accessibility and rigor as competing goals. Students can learn demanding material when the steps are visible and the purpose of each step is clear. I introduce notation gradually, explain the role of assumptions, and return to the economic question after presenting a formal result. I want students to leave with methods they can apply to everyday decisions, not a list of formulas they can reproduce only on an exam.

I also try to create a classroom in which questions are part of the work rather than evidence that a student does not belong. When we review a practice exam, I invite students to come to the board and explain a problem. This gives them a chance to practice presenting an argument, and it gives the class several ways to understand the same solution. At the same time, I set clear expectations for preparation and participation. Students should leave a class knowing both what they can do and what they still need to practice.

Courses I can teach

I am most eager to teach macroeconomics, public economics, and family economics at the undergraduate or graduate level. In macroeconomics, I would teach principles and intermediate courses that connect simple models of household and firm decisions to data on growth, saving, and public debt, and graduate courses in macroeconomic theory and computational methods, where I have served as a teaching assistant. In public economics, I would cover taxation, public spending, and government debt, drawing on my research on local government finance in China. In family economics, I would teach how households make decisions about marriage, fertility, education, and saving, and how public policy shapes those decisions. I am also capable and willing to teach courses outside my primary fields at the undergraduate or master's level. I am excited to mentor and advise students at all levels, including on research projects that use household survey data.

My aim is for students to see economics as a way to ask precise questions about choices and institutions, not as a collection of formulas. When students can explain the intuition, carry out the analysis, and interpret the result, they can use what they learned in a new setting.